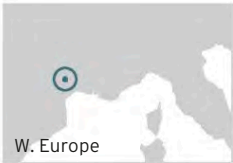


Millau Viaduct

A sublime cable-stayed bridge, built in response to the problem of modern traffic congestion



Until the opening of the Millau Viaduct in 2004, vacation traffic from Paris south to the Riviera and Spain caused regular congestion in the narrow Tarn valley near Millau in southern France. The first plans for a bridge to bypass the town were discussed in 1987, and four possible routes were surveyed. Each presented its own technical, geological, or environmental problems, but in 1991, the decision was made to build a viaduct over the River Tarn to the west of Millau.

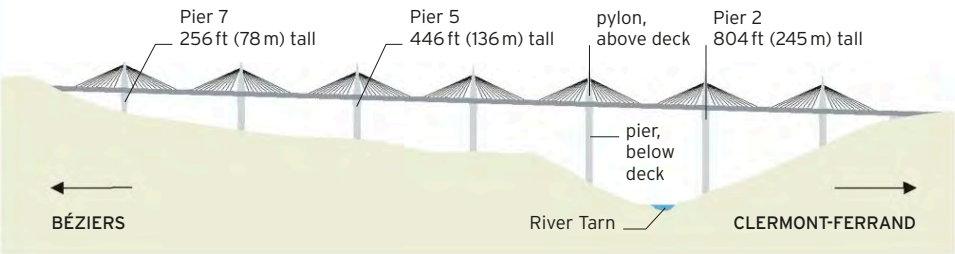
French-British cooperation

The resulting 8,200 ft (2,500 m) bridge, designed by British architect Norman Foster and French structural engineer Michel Virlogeux, stands more than 660 ft (200 m) above the river below. The deck on which the vehicles run is a lightweight steel structure that was prefabricated and then assembled on site. It is shaped like an inverted trapezoidal box that is cambered (sloped) on each side. Built at a total cost of \$442 million, the bridge was inaugurated on December 14, 2004, and opened for traffic 2 days later.

BUILDING THE DECK

Construction of the deck started on both sides of the Tarn valley, with sections rolled out from one pier to the next until they met in the middle. The deck is supported from below by piers and from above by stays attached to

vertical pylons. There are seven piers and pylons, creating two outer spans of 669 ft (204 m) each and six inner spans of 1,122 ft (342 m) each. The deck itself is 91 ft (28 m) and made of metal sheets 1/2 in (14 mm) wide.



Pylon 2 of the viaduct is **75 ft (23 m)** taller than the **Eiffel Tower**



THE TALLEST IN THE WORLD

Standing at a height of 1,125 ft (343 m), the Millau Viaduct is the tallest bridge in the world, 69 ft (21 m) taller than its nearest rival—the Bosphorus Bridge in Istanbul, Turkey.